

RAMP PROCUREMENT ACTIVATION CASE

NorthStar Aviation — Interview Prep & Role-Play Guide

THE ASSIGNMENT IN ONE SENTENCE

My job is not to conduct a generic discovery call. My job is to **lead NorthStar toward a practical future-state procurement workflow, validate the few decisions that matter, and leave with a concrete commitment to launch the first Spend Program and run a real request.**

Ramp specifically wants me to balance discovery with a **prescriptive point of view**, rather than simply listening to the customer describe their current process.

1. NORTHSTAR — WHAT I KNOW

Customer

- ~600-person aircraft manufacturer
- Builds and refurbishes aircraft for U.S. national and regional carriers
- Growing carrier contracts
- Expanding across additional U.S. regions
- Increasing vendor and aircraft-parts spend complexity
- Monica = Controller
- NetSuite is currently the purchasing/accounting system

Current process

Request

- Employees submit requests through email and Slack

Approval

- Inventory Manager first confirms purchase is needed
- Dollar thresholds determine C-level approval

Vendor

- Existing and new vendors follow different paths

PO / Invoice

- Invoices are manually matched to POs

Payment

- ACH and weekly check runs

Monica's problems

1. Approval speed

- Approvals are slow
- Bottlenecks cause aircraft-parts purchases to miss need-by dates

2. Audit readiness / accuracy

- Monica wants a clean, traceable record connecting: **requested** → **approved** → **received** → **invoiced** → **paid**

The assignment explicitly identifies these as the customer's priorities.

2. MY POINT OF VIEW

Don't try to redesign all of NorthStar's purchasing on Day 1.

Start with an **Aircraft Parts Spend Program**.

Why?

Aircraft parts are:

- operationally important
- time-sensitive
- a clear existing pain point
- structured enough to establish a repeatable workflow
- a good use case for approvals, POs, receiving and 3-way matching

The objective isn't to create the perfect procurement system immediately.

The objective is:

Get one real purchasing workflow running in Ramp, learn from it, and expand from there.

3. RECOMMENDED FUTURE STATE

Request

Requester submits an aircraft-parts request in Ramp.

Capture the information necessary to make a decision:

- Quantity
- Unit price / estimated price
- Need-by date
- Vendor
- Part number
- Any additional fields we determine are necessary during discovery

The important improvement:

No more email/Slack intake.

There is one front door for purchasing.

Approve

Route the request based on NorthStar's actual approval rules.

Questions to validate:

- What dollar thresholds exist today?
- Who approves at each threshold?
- Is the Inventory Manager actually an approver?
- Or is their role simply confirming that the purchase is operationally needed?

Don't assume the answer.

PO

After approval, create the PO in Ramp and sync it to NetSuite.

Ramp's current procurement workflow supports creating a PO after final approval and syncing procurement information with accounting systems.

Receive

This is one of the most important discovery questions.

Potential future states:

Option A — Receive in Ramp

Useful if NorthStar wants the receiving activity directly connected to the Ramp procurement workflow.

Option B — Receive in NetSuite

Potentially better if the warehouse / inventory team already lives in NetSuite and doesn't need another system for receiving.

Ramp supports NetSuite item receipts being used in 3-way matching, so the goal is not necessarily to force every process into Ramp.

My position:

Keep the system of record where it makes the most operational sense while connecting the workflow end-to-end.

Match & Pay

Invoice + PO + receipt = 3-way match.

Then:

Ramp Bill Pay → payment

This closes the loop from:

Request → Approval → PO → Receipt → Invoice → Payment

Ramp currently supports 3-way matching between bills, POs and item receipts, including scenarios where the PO and/or receipt originate in NetSuite.

This is a major part of Monica's desired audit trail.

4. THE FOUR DISCOVERY DECISIONS

Don't ask 15 questions.

Drive toward these four.

1. Inventory Manager

"Today the Inventory Manager confirms that a purchase is needed. Is that an actual approval, or are they providing visibility/accountability before the request moves to the financial approver?"

Why it matters:

Don't replicate unnecessary approval steps just because that's how the process works today.

If they're not truly approving, perhaps they're a reviewer / stakeholder rather than an approval gate.

2. Approval thresholds

"Can you walk me through the dollar thresholds today and who owns approval at each level?"

Then:

"Are those thresholds consistent across aircraft parts, or are there exceptions?"

Goal:

Understand the existing policy and translate it into Ramp.

3. Receiving

"Where does receiving actually happen today, and who is responsible for recording it?"

Then:

"Is the receiving team already operating in NetSuite, or would there be value in having that happen in Ramp?"

Goal:

Don't impose a system decision prematurely.

4. Required request fields

"Beyond quantity, price, need-by date, vendor and part number, what information does someone need today to determine whether an aircraft-parts request should be approved?"

Potential examples:

- aircraft / program
- cost center
- urgency
- reason / justification
- inventory availability
- substitute part
- vendor status

Don't invent these as requirements.

Discover first.

5. AI PROCUREMENT POLICIES

This should be a **value-add conversation**, not a product demo.

Ramp's current procurement AI agents can perform upfront research during procurement reviews, summarize risk/context and route the request based on results, while leaving the actual approval decision to humans.

How I should position it

"There's another area I'd want to explore as we build this: AI-powered procurement reviews. Rather than asking every approver to manually perform the same checks every time, we can look at where AI can gather information and surface exceptions before the request reaches the reviewer."

Then ask:

"Where do your reviewers spend the most time today validating a request?"

This makes AI relevant to **their process**, rather than dropping a random product feature into the conversation.

6. RAMP BILL PAY

This is an important part of the assignment.

Don't just say:

"Then the invoice goes to Bill Pay."

Sell the business outcome.

The pitch

"The reason I'd also recommend looking at Bill Pay is that it lets us close the loop. Today you've got purchasing in one process, manual invoice matching, and ACH/check runs. If the PO, receipt and invoice are connected in Ramp, Monica gets the traceability she's looking for and the AP team spends less time manually tying those records together."

Ramp supports matching bills to Ramp POs and can automatically match invoice line items to PO line items; with NetSuite, Ramp can also use NetSuite item receipts for 3-way matching.

The key phrase:

"Close the request-to-payment loop."

7. HOW I SHOULD RUN THE 15-MINUTE CONVERSATION

0:00–1:30 — Rapport + agenda

Don't launch into PowerPoint.

Say:

"Monica, it's great to meet you. I've reviewed the kickoff notes and have a pretty strong hypothesis for how I'd approach aircraft-parts purchasing in Ramp. I'd like to spend a few minutes walking you through that future state, then validate a handful of decisions with you, and if we're aligned, leave with a concrete first step we can actually launch this week. Does that sound good?"

This establishes:

- preparation

- confidence
 - structure
 - collaboration
-

8. SLIDE 1 — OPENING

What I say

"Based on what I've heard, I wouldn't recommend trying to transform all of NorthStar's purchasing at once. I'd start with aircraft parts because that's where you're seeing the most urgency around need-by dates and where we can create a repeatable workflow."

Then:

"The goal is to move from fragmented email and Slack requests to one controlled process in Ramp, while still using NetSuite where it makes sense operationally."

Then transition:

"Let me show you what that future state looks like."

9. SLIDE 2 — THE WORKFLOW

Request

"I'd start with a dedicated Aircraft Parts Spend Program. The requester has one place to submit the request, and we're capturing the information the approvers actually need."

Point to fields.

"These are the fields I'd start with based on what we know today. I don't want to over-engineer the form before we understand what your team actually needs."

Approve

"From there, the request follows your approval policy."

Then:

"One thing I specifically want to validate is the Inventory Manager's role. Are they actually approving the purchase, or are they confirming that it's operationally needed?"

This is a great discovery moment.

PO

"Once it's approved, the PO is created and can sync into NetSuite."

Receive

"For receiving, I'd want to understand where the team is most comfortable operating. If the warehouse team already records receipts in NetSuite, there's no reason to create unnecessary work just to move that activity."

This is an important statement.

It shows you're **not selling Ramp at the expense of the customer.**

Match & Pay

"Then we close the loop. The invoice gets matched against the PO and receipt, and Bill Pay handles the payment."

Then:

"That gets Monica much closer to the audit trail she's looking for: requested, approved, received, invoiced and paid."

10. DISCOVERY — THE CONVERSATION

After walking through the future state:

"Before I lock this in, there are four things I'd want to validate with you."

Then ask:

Question 1

"Let's start with Inventory. What's the Inventory Manager actually accountable for in today's process?"

Listen.

Follow up:

"If they didn't approve it, but simply confirmed inventory need, would you want that to remain a step in the workflow?"

Question 2

"What are your approval thresholds today?"

Listen.

Follow up:

"And are those thresholds based purely on dollar amount, or do certain types of purchases trigger additional review?"

Question 3

"Walk me through receiving. Where does the actual receipt get recorded today?"

Listen.

Follow up:

"Who would own that step in the future state?"

Question 4

"What information does an approver need before they feel comfortable approving an aircraft-parts request?"

Listen.

Then:

"That's probably what we should make mandatory in the request form."

11. IF MONICA PUSHES BACK

"We already use NetSuite. Why do we need Ramp?"

Don't get defensive.

Say:

"I wouldn't want to replace NetSuite just for the sake of replacing it. I'd use Ramp to solve the intake, approval and procurement workflow problems you're experiencing, while keeping NetSuite where it makes sense as the accounting or operational system of record."

Then:

"The integration is what makes that useful rather than creating another disconnected system."

"We don't want another system for receiving."

Say:

"That's completely reasonable. If the inventory team already lives in NetSuite, I'd rather keep receiving there and connect the receipt into the matching workflow than make them change systems unnecessarily."

Ramp's current documentation supports using NetSuite item receipts in the 3-way matching workflow.

"Our approval process is complicated."

Say:

"That's exactly why I'd rather model the real policy than force you into a generic approval chain. Let's understand the exceptions and determine which ones actually need to be represented in the workflow."

"We don't want AI making approval decisions."

Say:

"Agreed. I wouldn't position it that way. The value is having AI do the research and surface context or risk so the human reviewer can make a better decision faster."

Ramp's current procurement agents are designed to gather and summarize information; they do not approve or reject requests.

"We're not ready for Bill Pay."

Don't push too hard.

Say:

"That's fair. I'd still design the procurement workflow with the end state in mind so we don't create something that has to be rebuilt later. We can prove the procurement workflow first, then decide when you're ready to bring payment into the same loop."

This demonstrates customer empathy while still selling the expansion.

12. THE CLOSE

This is arguably the most important part.

Don't finish with:

"Any questions?"

Instead:

"Based on what we've discussed, I think we're ready to take a very small first step."

Then:

"I'd propose that we launch the Aircraft Parts Program, configure the approval path we just discussed, and run one real request through it this week."

Then ask:

"Who should be in that pilot group?"

After they answer:

"Great. Let's get the working session scheduled, build it together, run that first request, and then use what we learn to refine the workflow."

That's the win.

The assignment explicitly says success means getting the customer to commit to a first step such as standing up the first Spend Program and routing a first request.

13. WHAT RAMP IS REALLY EVALUATING

I would keep these five things in your head throughout the interview:

1. Can I lead?

Don't ask:

"So what would you like to do?"

Instead:

"Based on what I've heard, here's what I recommend. Let me validate a few assumptions."

2. Can I discover without being passive?

You have a recommendation.

But you're willing to change it.

3. Can I simplify?

NorthStar has a complicated procurement environment.

Your job is to make the first implementation **small and achievable**.

4. Can I sell?

You need to naturally introduce:

- Ramp Procurement
- AI procurement reviews
- Ramp Bill Pay

But everything should connect to a customer problem.

5. Can I drive activation?

The conversation must end with:

Who → does what → by when

Not:

"Great conversation, we'll follow up."

14. YOUR 30-SECOND CHEAT SHEET

If you only remember this, remember:

Problem

"NorthStar has fragmented intake, slow approvals and manual invoice matching."

Point of view

"Start with aircraft parts rather than trying to transform everything."

Future state

"Request → approval → PO → receipt → invoice → payment."

Discovery

"Validate Inventory's role, approval thresholds, receiving ownership and required request information."

AI

"Use AI to gather context and surface exceptions so reviewers can make decisions faster."

Bill Pay

"Close the request-to-payment loop and create the audit trail Monica wants."

Close

"Launch the Aircraft Parts Program and run one real request this week."

15. THINGS NOT TO DO

Don't over-explain Ramp.

This isn't a product demo.

Don't read the slides.

Use them as your map.

Don't ask endless discovery questions.

Four good questions > fifteen mediocre questions.

Don't pretend you know NorthStar's process.

Say:

"Here's my recommendation; let's validate it."

Don't make AI the centerpiece.

It's a supporting value proposition.

Don't force receiving into Ramp.

Use the system that makes operational sense.

Don't end without a commitment.

The final outcome should be a **pilot + working session + first request**.

16. PART 2 — PRIORITIZATION FRAMEWORK

You will get four scenarios with no preparation.

For every scenario, quickly ask yourself:

1. Does this threaten activation?

If yes → high priority.

2. Does this block a real customer from running procurement?

If yes → high priority.

3. Is this urgent or merely important?

Urgent customer blockers come first.

4. Can I resolve it myself?

If yes → do it.

If not → identify the right internal owner and communicate next steps.

5. Does solving it unlock adoption?

That's the strongest signal.

A simple ranking framework

P1 — Customer is blocked

Example:

Customer cannot submit requests / approval workflow is broken / critical implementation blocker.

Action: Address immediately.

P2 — Customer can launch but activation is at risk

Example:

Key stakeholder hasn't completed configuration or pilot group isn't aligned.

Action: Drive to resolution quickly.

P3 — Important optimization

Example:

Customer wants a more sophisticated workflow that isn't necessary for initial launch.

Action: Capture it, but don't let it derail activation.

P4 — Nice-to-have

Example:

Reporting customization or future enhancement.

Action: Defer.

The core principle:

Optimize for getting customers live, not for solving every problem immediately.

17. FINAL MINDSET

I'm not trying to prove that I know every Ramp feature.

I'm demonstrating that I can:

Understand the customer's problem → form a hypothesis → lead discovery → adapt → simplify → activate → expand.

That is the job.